After the attack, Anil Pandit, 32, a US-based gangster from Panipat, and his overseas associate Harman Sandhu claimed responsibility on behalf of the Bishnoi gang, saying they had warned Shroff not to associate with actor Salman Khan, a longstanding target of the gang. However, police sources say Shroff had not lodged a complaint about any threats. Raj Tilak Roushan, deputy commissioner of police (detection), Crime Branch, Mumbai Police, says the claims are being verified. "We cannot take them at face value." Pandit also demanded that Salman apologise to his 'brother' Lawrence and the Bishnoi community. The actor has long faced the community's ire over the alleged killing of two blackbucks in Rajasthan in 1998. The animal is revered by the Bishnois.

The threat has unsettled the film industry. The All India Cine Workers Association and the Federation of Western India Cine Employees have sought enhanced security for film personalities. Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis has promised action, saying that "all those involved in this will be traced and no one will be spared".

## THE RECCE AND AFTER

Shroff had a narrow escape, according to investigators, because one of the shooters, Rehan, either struggled to cock his weapon or it jammed. Phool fired five rounds at the actor's car, hitting the driver. Shroff instinctively ducked backwards to avoid the bullets, but sustained injuries from shattered glass. The manner in which the shots were fired indicated an intent to murder, says Roushan.

After the shooting, the trio fled on a motorcycle, with Hrithik at the wheel. They abandoned the vehicle near Andheri West railway station, took a train to Borivali and then a cab to Surat, before boarding a Jaipur-Pune train. Their trail unravelled quickly. Mumbai Police traced the motorcycle to its seller, while Hrithik's call to a taxi driver in Surat helped the police alert their counterparts in Gujarat, Rajasthan and Delhi. Acting on information from Mumbai Police about the train compartment, Rajasthan Police arrested the three at Kota, within 15 hours of the attack.

The arrests also helped investigators piece together how Shroff became a target. He may not have been the gang's first choice, with the shooters reportedly conducting reconnaissance at the homes of Salman, Amitabh Bachchan and Aamir Khan. Daunted by their security, they turned their attention to Shroff. Roushan refuses to "confirm or deny" these reports.

The men travelled around Mumbai in autorickshaws, posing as fans seeking photographs of celebrities' homes. Their handlers had asked them to identify stars with relatively weak security. Shroff emerged as a more accessible target. An autorickshaw driver reportedly told them about his Sunday football routine. The shooters, allegedly assisted by Ankit, conducted a recce on October 11, but Shroff did not turn up. They returned on October 18. "This is perhaps because the Bishnoi gang wanted to take on a high-value

# THE JUHU SHOOTING

*A planned attack, a quick getaway and 10 arrests spanning four states*

**↘ WEEKS BEFORE**
**The alleged attackers—Hrithik, Rehan and Phool—surveil the location where Tiger Shroff practises football. Police sources say the planning spans a few weeks. One accused buys the motorcycle used in the attack for Rs 25,000 in cash on Sept. 11**

**↘ About a fortnight before the shooting, Kunal and Sumit collect weapons in Amritsar. On Oct. 15, two women are sent to Mumbai with those**

**↘ OCT. 18, AROUND 7 PM**
**As Shroff prepares to leave Pushpa Narsee Park in his BMW after a football session, two assailants allegedly open fire at the car, while the third waits on the motorcycle. One firearm reportedly jams**



**↘ SHROFF ESCAPES**
**The actor gets away without gunshot injuries. His driver is shot in the left hand, while a bystander sustains a bullet wound to the chest**

**↘ THE GETAWAY**
**The assailants flee towards SV Road and Andheri railway station area, abandon the motorcycle, take a local train to Borivali and book a cab to Surat**

**↘ TEN ARRESTS**
**On Oct. 19, the Juhu trio are arrested at Kota railway station. Later, seven others are held in Delhi and Haryana for allegedly supplying weapons and logistics**

### WHY TIGER SHROFF?



**↘ HIGH-VALUE TARGET**
**The gang may have targeted Shroff to strike fear in Bollywood and extort money**

**↘ EASY ACCESS**
**He moved without security, making him more vulnerable to an attack**

**↘ WIDER INTIMIDATION**
**The shooting may have been intended to expand the gang's footprint in Mumbai**